Required Reading

Please read the assigned excerpt on **World Literature** by Ben Hutchinson before coming to class.

This excerpt does not define World Literature as a simple list of famous books from many countries. Instead, it asks us to think about how literature travels, how it is translated, how it is selected for study, and how power shapes the idea of "the world."

Purpose

As you read, focus on the question:

What does "World Literature" mean, and who gets to decide what belongs to it?

Do not read the excerpt only for information. Read it as an argument about the history, limits, and possibilities of World Literature as a field of study.

I. Main Ideas to Notice

While reading, pay attention to these key ideas:

1. World Literature and Comparison

The excerpt shows that World Literature grows out of comparative literature, but it also challenges older models of comparison. Earlier forms of comparison often centered Europe and treated non-European literatures as secondary or peripheral.

Ask:

Does comparison always create understanding, or can it also create hierarchy?

2. Postcolonial Critique

The excerpt discusses ideas such as **Orientalism**, **diversity**, **hybridity**, and **postcolonialism**. These ideas remind us that literature is often read through unequal relations between colonizer and colonized, center and margin, observer and observed.

Ask:

How can World Literature avoid turning other cultures into objects of Western observation?

3. Tagore and Vishwa Sahitya

The excerpt introduces Rabindranath Tagore's idea of **Vishwa Sahitya**, or World Literature. Tagore does not treat literature as a mere collection of national works. He imagines literature as part of a larger human creativity that crosses narrow national boundaries.

Ask:

How is Tagore's idea of World Literature different from simply comparing national literatures?

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4. Spivak and Planetarity

The excerpt also discusses Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's idea of **planetarity**. Spivak criticizes models of World Literature that are too closely tied to globalization, standardization, and metropolitan centers. Her idea of the "planet" suggests a more ethical and less market-driven way of thinking about literary relations.

Ask:

What is the difference between thinking of literature globally and thinking of it planetarily?

5. Damrosch: Circulation and Reading

The excerpt presents David Damrosch's influential view that World Literature is not a fixed canon, but a **mode of circulation and reading**. A work becomes world literature when it travels beyond its original language and culture and is read as literature in new contexts.

Ask:

Does a text become "world literature" because it is great, because it travels, or because readers in different places give it new meanings?

6. Translation and Untranslatability

The excerpt ends by stressing the importance and difficulty of translation. Translation makes World Literature possible, but it may also simplify, distort, or standardize texts. Emily Apter's critique reminds us that some words, ideas, and cultural meanings may resist easy translation.

Ask:

What is gained and what is lost when we read world literature in translation?

II. While Reading

Please mark or note:

- one sentence that helps define **World Literature**;
- one sentence that criticizes Eurocentric or Western-centered models of comparison;
- one idea connected to **Tagore**;
- one idea connected to **Spivak**;
- one idea connected to **Damrosch**;
- one sentence about translation or untranslatability;
- one idea you find difficult, confusing, or debatable.

III. Main Reflection Question

After reading the excerpt, answer this question in brief notes:

Based on the excerpt, what would make a World Literature syllabus good, limited, or problematic?

You may think about a syllabus you have studied, a syllabus from another class, or a World Literature syllabus you find online.

Do not only ask whether the syllabus includes many countries. Ask deeper questions:

- What idea of "the world" does this syllabus create?
- Which regions, languages, and traditions are centered?
- Which voices are missing?
- Does the syllabus pay attention to translation?
- Does it treat literature as a fixed canon or as something that circulates across cultures?
- Does it include non-Western theories of World Literature?
- Does it allow the Global South to speak in its own terms?

IV. Dream Syllabus Question

Prepare one short answer to the following question:

If you could design your own "dream syllabus" for a World Literature course, what would it look like?

Your answer should include:

- a title for your course;
- 5–7 authors or texts;
- at least 4 different regions or literary traditions;
- at least 2 works originally written in languages other than English;
- one explanation of how your syllabus responds to the problems raised in the excerpt.

V. Bring to Class

Please bring:

1. one key idea from the excerpt;
2. one quotation or sentence you want to discuss;

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3. one problem you see in traditional World Literature syllabi;
4. one idea for your own dream syllabus;
5. one question you still have about World Literature.

Working Principle

excerpt → concept → syllabus critique → dream syllabus

Do not begin with the assumption that World Literature means "literature from many countries."

Begin with the harder question:

What kind of world is being imagined when we call something World Literature?